

LESSON 2

The Narrative Present: Participles and Enclitics

SECTION 1: REVIEW OF LESSON 1

Quick Summary

In Lesson 1, we established the basic building blocks of Syriac syntax. We learned that Syriac sentences do not strictly require a “to be” verb; rather, placing a subject and predicate side-by-side with a matching independent pronoun acts as an equational sentence (e.g., *Malkā hū ṭābā* — “The king [is] good”). We also looked at the absolute versus empathic states of nouns, with the emphatic ending in *ā* (Alaph) acting as the default dictionary form.

5-Question Warm-Up Drill

(Answers in Section 9)

1. Translate: *Alāhā rabbā hū*.
 2. What is the Syriac absolute state for “word” (from *meltā*)?
 3. How do you say “We” in Syriac?
 4. What particle is used to express “of”, “who”, or “that”?
 5. In *Malkūtā d-Alāhā hī*, why is the pronoun *hī* (she) used instead of *hū* (he)?
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SECTION 2: THE PARTICIPLE AS PRESENT TENSE — OVERVIEW

In Indo-European languages like English, and Greek, the “present tense” is a fully conjugated finite verb (e.g., “I walk”, *περιπατῶ*). Participles are verbal adjectives (e.g., “the *walking* man”).

In Aramaic and Syriac, the **active participle** stepped in to take over the function of the present tense almost entirely. A Syriac speaker didn’t say “I write” as a finite verb; they literally said “Writing [am] I.”

Cross-Linguistic Comparison

- **Hebrew:** Biblical Hebrew primarily used the Imperfect for ongoing action, but by the Mishnaic period (interfacing with Aramaic), Hebrew also adopted the participle for the present tense (e.g., *ānī kōtēb* = I am writing).

- **Arabic:** Standard Arabic relies on the imperfect prefix conjugation (يَكْتُبُ *yaktubu*, “he writes”). The active participle (كَاتِبٌ *kātib*) means “writer” or “one who has written,” but does not serve as a primary present tense verb.
 - **Greek:** Syriac’s reliance on the participle to form continuous action heavily influenced how Syriac translators rendered Greek continuous tenses (often translating a Greek present indicative with a Syriac participle + pronoun).
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SECTION 3: THE PEAL ACTIVE PARTICIPLE & ENCLITICS

The Peal Stem

Semitic verbs exist in different “stems” (or binyanim) that modify their meaning. The basic, un-augmented ground-stem is called the **Pearl**. Almost all basic actions occur in the Pearl.

Forming the Participle

For a strong tri-consonantal root (C-C-C) like *k-t-b* (write), the active participle is formed by inserting a long *ā* after the first consonant, and an *e* after the second.

- *kāteb* (writing, m.sg.)
- *kātbā* (writing, f.sg.)

Enclitic Pronouns

To turn “writing” into “I am writing,” Syriac attaches an **enclitic** pronoun to the back of the participle. Enclitics are shortened, rhythmic versions of the independent pronouns from Lesson 1.

- *'enā* (I) → *-nā*
 - *kāteb* + *-nā* = *kāteb-nā* (I am writing)
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SECTION 4: PARTICIPLE AND ENCLITIC PARADIGMS

1. The Enclitic Pronoun Set

PERSON	INDEPENDENT	ENCLITIC FORM	ATTACHED EXAMPLE (<i>KĀTEB</i>)	TRANSLATION
1 c.sg.	'enā	-nā	kāteb-nā / kātbā-nā	I am writing
2 m.sg.	'ant	-t	kāteb-t	You (m) are writing
2 f.sg.	'anti	-tī	kātbā-tī	You (f) are writing
3 m.sg.	hū	-hū / (none)*	kāteb / kāteb-hū	He is writing / writes
3 f.sg.	hī	-hī / (none)*	kātbā / kātbā-hī	She is writing / writes
1 c.pl.	ḥnan	-ḥnan	kātbīn-ḥnan / kātbān-ḥnan	We are writing
2 m.pl.	'antūn	-tūn	kātbīn-tūn	You (m.pl) are writing
2 f.pl.	'antēn	-tēn	kātbān-tēn	You (f.pl) are writing
3 m.pl.	hennōn	(none)**	kātbīn	They (m) are writing
3 f.pl.	hennēn	(none)**	kātbān	They (f) are writing

**In the 3rd person singular, the participle often stands entirely alone without an enclitic. **In the 3rd person plural, the plural suffix (-īn / -ān) is sufficient; no enclitic is added.*

2. The Peal Active Participle Declension (Root **k-t-b**)

GENDER/NUM	ESTRANGELA	TRANSLITERATION
Masc. Sg.	כּתב	kāteb
Fem. Sg.	כּתבָּ	kātbā
Masc. Pl.	כּתבּוּ	kātbīn
Fem. Pl.	כּתבּוֹן	kātbān

SECTION 5: SENTENCE SYNTAX

When the active participle drives the sentence, the word order is very fluid, but Verb-Subject-Object (VSO) or Subject-Verb-Object (SVO) are both common.

- **SVO:** *Yūḥannan kāteb meltā.* (Yukhannan writes a word).
- **VSO:** *Kāteb Yūḥannan meltā.* (Writes Yukhannan a word).
- **Enclitic:** *Kāteb-nā meltā.* (I am writing a word).

SECTION 6: VOCABULARY (STRONG VERBS & ADVERBS)

ROOT	PEAL PTCP (M.S.)	MEANING	ADVERB/PARTICLE	MEANING
כ.ת.ב	kāteb	to write	כַּעַתָּה (hāšā)	now
א.ל.א	'āzel	to go	דֵּן (dēn)	but, then, however
א.מ.ר	'āmer	to speak/say	תַּמָּאֵן (tammān)	there
ש.מ.ע	šāma ' *	to hear	לְעֵל (l' el)	above
ר.א.ו	hāzē	to see	הֵכָא (harkā)	here
ע.ב.ד	'ābed	to do/make	עִם (' am)	with
נ.א.ר	nāter	to keep/guard	עַל (' al)	upon, against
ר.א.ד	rādep	to pursue		
ש.ב.ע	šābeq	to leave		
נ.א.ע	nāpeq	to go out		

*Note: Roots ending in gutturals (like 'Ayn) change the **e** to an **a** (šāma ' instead of šāme ').

SECTION 7: THE STORY — PART 2

Preparation

Narrative note: The present tense (participle + enclitics) is used here to create an immediate, action-oriented dialogue as Yukhannan prepares his disciples.

Sentence 1

ቢሉ ሕድረ ነገሥት ደብዳቤ Yūḥannan ’āmer l-talmīdē d-īt l-eh. Yūḥannan (John) ’āmer (is-speaking) l- (to) talmīdē (the-disciples) d- (that) īt (there-are) l-eh (to-him). → Yukhannan is speaking to the disciples that are his.

Sentence 2

אֶזֶל נָא מֵעַן הֵרָא 'āzel-nā men harkā. 'āzel (going) -nā (am-I) men (from) harkā (here). → “I am going from here.”

Sentence 3

אזל נא ל מלכותא ד בישא, אמר הו. 'āzel (going) -nā (am-I) l-
(to) malkūttā (the-kingdom) d- (of) bišā (the-evil-[one]), 'āmer (says) -hū (he). → “I am going to the
kingdom of the evil one,” he says.

Sentence 4

ܬܠܡܝܕܝܫܡܝܢ talmidē šām ' in meltā d-Yūḥannan. talmidē (the-disciples) šām ' in (are-hearing) meltā (the-word) d- (of) Yūḥannan (John). → The disciples hear the word of Yukhannan.

Sentence 5

ܐܡܪܝܢ ܗܝܠܝܢ ܡܠܟܐ ܒܝܫܐ ܬܡܡܐܢ. ܗܝܠܝܢ (they)
'āmṛīn (are-saying): ḥāzēn (seeing) -ḥnan (are-we) malkā (a-king) bīšā (evil) tammān (there). → They say:
“We see an evil king there.”

Sentence 6

נְהַרְרָא חֲבֵד נְהַרְרָא חֲבֵד Yūḥannan ‘ābed nūhrā b-’ar ‘ā. Yūḥannan (John) ‘ābed (is-making/doing) nūhrā (light) b- (in) ’ar ‘ā (the-earth). → Yukhannan makes light in the earth.

Sentence 7

ᐱᓄ ᐃᓂᐳ ᐱᓄᐳ ᐱᓄᐳ ᐱᓄᐳ kāteb-nā meltā d-Alāhā, ’āmer hāšā. kāteb (writing) -nā (am-I)
meltā (the-word) d- (of) Alāhā (God), ’āmer (says-[he]) hāšā (now). → “I am writing the word of God,” he
says now.

SECTION 8: EXERCISES

Exercise 1: Participle Identification

Identify the gender and number of the following participles.

1. ܕܠܒܝܢ (kātḇīn)
2. ܫܡܐܐ (šām ‘ ā)
3. ܢܦܩܢܐܢ (nāpqān)
4. ܪܕܦܐ (rādep)

Exercise 2: Conjugation Drill

Combine the root ‘-b-d (to do, make) with the correct enclitic pronoun to form the present tense for:

1. I am making (m.sg)
2. We are making (m.pl)
3. You (f.sg) are making
4. They (m.pl) are making.

Exercise 3: Translation Drill (Syriac → English)

Translate the following present tense clauses.

1. ‘āzel-nā l-malkūttā.
2. Šām ‘īn-tūn meltā d-Alāhā.
3. Barnāšā bīšā rādep l-Yūḥannan.
4. Ḥāzēn-ḥnan nūhrā rabbā tammān.

Exercise 4: Production Drill (English → Syriac)

Render the following active present sentences into Syriac transliteration.

1. I (m) am hearing the word.
2. She is writing a good word.
3. They (m) are going from here.
4. You (m.pl) are seeing the king.

Exercise 5: Reading Comprehension

Re-read Section 7 and answer:

1. From where does Yūkhannan say he is going?
 2. What do the disciples fear they will see there?
 3. What is Yūkhannan “writing” right now?
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SECTION 9: ANSWER KEY

Section 1 Warm-Up

1. God is great.
2. *Melt* (ܡܠܬ)
3. *ḥnan*
4. *d-*
5. Because *malkūtā* (kingdom) is a feminine noun.

Exercise 1: Participle Identification

1. Masculine Plural
2. Feminine Singular
3. Feminine Plural
4. Masculine Singular

Exercise 2: Conjugation Drill

1. ‘ābed-nā
2. ‘ābdīn-ḥnan
3. ‘ābdā-tī
4. ‘ābdīn (no enclitic needed for 3rd person pl)

Exercise 3: Translation Drill

1. I am going to the kingdom.
2. You all are hearing the word of God.
3. The evil man is pursuing Yūkhannan.
4. We are seeing a great light there.

Exercise 4: Production Drill

1. Šāma^ʿ -nā meltā.
2. Kātbā meltā ṭābtā.
3. ʾĀzlīn men harkā.
4. Ḥāzēn-tūn l-malkā.

Exercise 5: Reading Comprehension

1. “From here” (*men harkā*).
2. An evil king (*malkā bīšā*).
3. The word of God (*meltā d-Alāhā*).

SECTION 10: GRAMMATICAL SUMMARY

PARTICIPLE + ENCLITIC COMBINATIONS (Masc. Root k-t-b)

ENGLISH	PARTICIPLE	ENCLITIC	COMBINED SYRIAC FORM
I write (m)	kāteb	-nā	kāteb-nā
You write (m)	kāteb	-t	kāteb-t
He writes	kāteb	(-hū)	kāteb / kāteb-hū
We write (m)	kātbīn	-ḥnan	kātbīn-ḥnan
You all write (m)	kātbīn	-tūn	kātbīn-tūn
They write (m)	kātbīn	(none)	kātbīn

SECTION 11: ADDITIONAL VOCABULARY

The following 30 genuinely new high-frequency words supplement this lesson's vocabulary, focusing on

nouns and derived verbal nouns relevant to narrative present (participle) usage.

SYRIAC (ESTRANGELA)	TRANSLITERATION	PART OF SPEECH	MEANING	NOTES
ܫܒܬܐ	šabbtā	f. noun	sabbath, week	pl. šabbē
ܠܒܫܐ	lbūšā	m. noun	garment, clothing	from root l-b-š (to wear)
ܕܟܪܐܢܐ	dəkrānā	m. noun	memory, remembrance	from root d-k-r (to remember)
ܩܥܬܐ	pəg' ānā	m. noun	encounter, meeting	from root p-g-ʿ (to meet)
ܐܫܒܐ	'əṣḅ' ā	f. noun	finger	body part, abstract
ܩܠܬܐ	pūlhānā	m. noun	labor, toil	from root p-l-ḥ (to serve)
ܫܡܪܐܢܐ	šəmrānā	m. noun	guard, watchfulness	from root š-m-r (to guard)
ܕܠܬܐ	gəməlūtā	f. noun	kindness, mercy	from root g-m-l (to treat well)
ܠܕܬܐ	ləgdattā	f. noun	overtaking, capture	from root l-g-d (to reach)
ܕܠܬܐ	dəlūtā	f. noun	poverty, want	abstract noun
ܩܠܬܐ	pəlgūtā	f. noun	division, share	from root p-l-g (to divide)
ܩܠܬܐ	qəlpəttā	f. noun	shell, exterior	
ܪܘܓܝܐܢܐ	rūgzānā	m. noun	rage, wrath	from root r-g-z (to shake)
ܕܝܕܐ	y-dā' ūttā	f. noun	knowledge	from root y-d-ʿ (to know)
ܩܦܪܐ	kəprā	m. noun	village, hamlet	place noun
ܩܦܪܐ	pəqrā	m. noun	opening, aperture	from root p-q-r (to open)

SYRIAC (ESTRANGELA)	TRANSLITERATION	PART OF SPEECH	MEANING	NOTES
ܕܝܡܪܬܐ	gəmrūtā	f. noun	completion, fulfillment	from root g-m-r (to complete)
ܕܝܫܢܐ	ṭūšānā	m. noun	strength, might	from root ṭ-w-š (to be strong)
ܕܝܥܬܐ	šəp ‘ ā	m. noun	abundance, plenty	from root š-p- ‘ (to suffice)
ܕܠܡܐ	laḥmā	m. noun	bread, food	staple item
ܕܡܫܐ	pəsmā	m. noun	measure, standard	
ܕܫܠܡܬܐ	šəlmūtā	f. noun	completeness, wholeness	from root š-l-m (to be whole)
ܕܠܩܐ	‘ alqā	m. noun	ascent, stairway	from root ‘-l-q (to ascend)
ܕܓܪܢܐ	gəṭrānā	m. noun	enclosure, fence	from root g-ṭ-r (to fence)
ܕܫܢܘܬܐ	šənūtā	f. noun	change, alteration	from root š-n-y (to change)
ܕܕܒܩܘܬܐ	dəbqūtā	f. noun	clinging, adherence	from root d-b-q (to cling)
ܕܩܕܫܘܬܐ	qdūšūtā	f. noun	holiness, sanctity	from root q-d-š (to be holy)
ܕܕܘܠܘܬܐ	gdūlūtā	f. noun	greatness, grandeur	from root g-d-l (to be great)
ܕܐܪܘܬܐ	‘ ərūtā	f. noun	nakedness, shame	from root ‘-r-y (to be naked)
ܕܒܪܢܐ	dəbrānā	m. noun	word, matter	related to d-b-r
ܕܪܡܘܬܐ	rūmūtā	f. noun	height, elevation	from root r-w-m (to be high)